

Teaching Digital Safety and Cybersecurity in K-12: Course Syllabus (3 Credit Hours)

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-linked, in the order the lessons take them.

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Hackles College Edition, Part A. A ready-to-adopt course for education and teacher-preparation programs and for in-service teacher graduate courses.

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TO VERIFY

Adopting institutions: what to fill in. Everything in [SQUARE BRACKETS AND CAPITALS] is a local decision: course number, instructor, meeting times, campus offices, term dates. Everything marked [VERIFY] needs a primary-source check before you rely on it. Legal points are marked [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]. This course has not been evaluated, accredited or approved by any state education agency, accrediting body or licensing board. Nothing here claims that Hackles is effective: no controlled trial of Hackles exists.

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
Pathway note (for adult readers; this is the only place it appears in the course). Hackles is the first step on a learning path that continues with free resources such as picoCTF and CYBER.ORG, and for college and professional learners tools like Competence Collective's Red Herrings (redherrings.app) and Hotwash (hotwa.sh). This note is for adults only and never appears in student materials.	

01 Course information

ITEM	DETAIL
Course title	Teaching Digital Safety and Cybersecurity in K-12
Course number	EDU 4xx / 5xx [INSTITUTION TO ASSIGN]
Credit	3 semester credit hours [VERIFY conversion for quarter systems with your registrar]
Contact hours	45 clock hours over 15 weeks (3 hours per week, 180 minutes)
Field experience	At least 12 on-site hours (outside the 45), or your own classroom for in-service teachers, with a mentor teacher present
Prerequisites	None. No technical background needed. Field work requires a cleared background check and completed mandated-reporter orientation [VERIFY your state and district requirements]
Meets	[DAY, TIME, ROOM or ONLINE SYNCHRONOUS LINK]
Instructor	[NAME, OFFICE, EMAIL, OFFICE HOURS]
Counselor partner	[NAME and role: campus counseling center liaison or a school counselor], present in Weeks 8 and 9 and available all term
Required materials	The free Hackles kit (Teacher Academy, Concepts Lab, Facilitator Kit, Disclosure and Incident Guide, Assessment Pack). No textbook purchase. See the Reading List
Delivery	Face to face, hybrid or synchronous online. Every activity has a paper version

Credit-hour note. This design assumes the federal expectation of about one hour of class and two hours of out-of-class work per credit hour per week [VERIFY with your registrar; 34 CFR 600.2]. Out-of-class work is reading, journals, the unit plan, the capstone and field preparation. If your institution counts field hours toward contact time, say so in the catalog [REGISTRAR TO CONFIRM].

02 Catalog description

PREPARES FUTURE AND CURRENT K-12 teachers to teach digital safety and cybersecurity with skills-first methods. Candidates learn the real risks and the evidence behind them, practice basic security habits with fake data, plan and teach 15-minute lessons, rehearse the first ten minutes after a student's disclosure, include every learner and family, and measure their teaching honestly. Includes a supervised field experience, background-check and mandated-reporter orientation. No technical background required.

03 Why this course exists

MOST TEACHERS WERE NEVER taught how to talk with a ten-year-old about a stranger in a game chat, or how to answer a student who says, "My friend got a weird message." Many have never been told what to do in the first ten minutes after a child tells them something hard. This course closes those gaps.

The routine is simple and the same one students learn: **Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.** If you can listen, stay calm and run a good 15-minute activity, you can teach this. You do not need to be a cybersecurity expert. You do need to be honest about what the evidence shows, careful with sensitive moments, and kind.

04 Course learning outcomes

BY THE END OF the course, candidates will be able to do the following. Each outcome maps to one of the six Hackles Teacher Academy competencies (A Know, B Protect, C Connect, D Teach, E Respond, F Include and grow), to the InTASC Model Core Teaching Standards, and to the ISTE Standards for Educators. **[VERIFY all standards codes against the current official documents before publishing: the kit verified the ISTE Student Standards and the CSTA codes, but not the InTASC or ISTE Educator numbering. ISTE renumbered its student standards in 2023, so confirm the current educator numbering too.]**

{{CLO_TABLE}}

Standards used in the table (titles only; paraphrased, [VERIFY]).

- InTASC: 1 Learner Development; 2 Learning Differences; 3 Learning Environments; 4 Content Knowledge; 5 Application of Content; 6 Assessment; 7 Planning for Instruction; 8 Instructional Strategies; 9 Professional Learning and Ethical Practice; 10 Leadership and Collaboration.
- ISTE Standards for Educators (2017 numbering as recalled): 1 Learner; 2 Leader; 3 Citizen; 4 Collaborator; 5 Designer; 6 Facilitator; 7 Analyst. Indicators cited: 1a set learning goals and use research-supported pedagogy; 1c stay current with research; 2b advocate for equitable access; 3b culture of critical examination of online resources and media fluency; 3c mentor students in safe, legal and ethical practices; 3d model management of personal data and protect student data privacy; 4d cultural competence with students, parents and colleagues; 5a adapt learning for learner differences; 5b design authentic learning aligned to

standards; 7a to 7c alternative demonstrations of learning, assessments that inform instruction, and assessment data shared with stakeholders.

Standards students will map to in their units (see Week 12). CSTA K-12 CS Standards (2017, revised; codes verified in the kit), ISTE Standards for Students (2023 numbering: 1.2 Digital Citizen, 1.3 Knowledge Constructor), CASEL's five competencies, and the candidate's own state standards. Say "mapped to," never "certified."

05 How the course teaches

EVERY WEEK FOLLOWS THE same shape, so nobody has to wonder what is next: an opening ritual, short input, **practice** (the Teacher Academy "Do it yourself" activities, Concepts Lab demos you do first and then teach, and Facilitator Kit methods such as the Fake Phish Derby, Say-It-Right Relay and Disclosure Role-Play with Safety Rails), discussion, and a calm close.

- **Concepts Lab.** Fourteen mostly unplugged demos. You do each one first (Do, Debrief, Teach), then learn to teach it in 15 or 45 minutes. Defense only; no real systems, accounts, malware or people.
- **Facilitator Kit methods.** The same activities used to train staff, so you experience what you will later lead.
- **Fake data only.** Every hands-on activity uses invented people and invented accounts. Nobody types, shares or screenshots a real password, a real student or a real private image.
- **Field experience.** Observation, then two supervised lessons, then a family or community workshop (see the Field Placement Guide).

06 Weekly schedule

EACH WEEK IS 180 minutes. Readings are due before class. Full week-by-week plans, with minute-by-minute agendas, are in the Weekly Course Plans document and in each LMS module.

{{SCHEDULE}}

Week 8 and 9 are high-care weeks. Both use fictional, non-graphic cards, traffic-light cards, a counselor partner and a de-role step. The written alternative is always available. See Section 12.

07 **Assessment plan**

ASSESSMENT	WHAT IT SHOWS	WHEN	WEIGHT
Module quizzes (8) and surveys	Knowledge of module content; self-awareness	Weeks 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 9, 11, 14; surveys Weeks 1 and 13	10%
Reflective journal	Honest reflection on your own practice and growth	Weeks 1 to 13 (best 12 of 13 count)	10%
Micro-teach of a 15-minute Hackles lesson	Competency D (Teach)	Week 7	15%
Disclosure-response practicum (fictional cards only)	Competency E (Respond); the Response Readiness gate	Week 9 (retake allowed)	15%
Unit plan	Competencies D and F; standards and evidence	Proposal Week 5; draft Week 12; final Week 13	20%
Capstone: a family or community workshop	Competencies D, F; partnering with families	Proposal Week 11; plan Week 14; delivery Weeks 14 to 15	20%
Field log, supervised lessons and professional dispositions	Professional practice	Weeks 4 to 15	10%

RUBRICS, DIRECTIONS AND THE practicum card deck are in the Assignments and Rubrics document.

Response Readiness gate. Candidates may deliver supervised lessons in a K-12 classroom only after they (1) meet the practicum standard (at least 9 of 11 checklist items; retakes allowed) and (2) submit a Contact Card and Reporting Map verified with a school administrator, counselor or the field office. Observation and co-planning are allowed before the gate. The gate follows the Academy's rule that response readiness matters most for child safety.

Mastery and revision. Quizzes need 8 of 10 (best of two attempts). The micro-teach and practicum allow revision and retake without penalty. The goal is competence, not a curve.

08 **Grading scheme**

{{GRADE_TABLE}}

PERCENT	LETTER
93 to 100	A
90 to 92	A-
87 to 89	B+
83 to 86	B
80 to 82	B-

PERCENT	LETTER
77 to 79	C+
73 to 76	C
70 to 72	C-
60 to 69	D
Below 60	F

[INSTITUTION: adjust to your grading policy, including pass/fail options and graduate-level thresholds (many graduate programs require a B or better).] A candidate who has not met the Response Readiness gate by the last day of Week 11 receives an Incomplete and a plan for completion [INSTITUTION POLICY]. The Academy's own certificate (Hackles-Ready) is separate from the course grade, is honor-system, and carries no accreditation or licensure claim.

Late work. Journals and discussion posts: one week grace with no penalty if you tell the instructor. Unit plan and capstone: contact the instructor before the due date; extensions are given for illness, bereavement, field-placement disruption and accessibility needs. Quizzes may be retaken until the end of Week 15.

Attendance. Class practice is the learning, so attend if you can. Missed sessions can be made up with the materials and a short written reflection; the high-care weeks (8 and 9) need a make-up plan with the instructor and counselor partner.

09 Accessibility statement

THIS COURSE IS BUILT so that every candidate can take part.

- **Many ways in.** Most activities can be done by speaking, writing, drawing, pointing or acting. In role-plays you may choose Teacher, Observer, or the written alternative; reading the Student lines aloud is also fine. Nobody has to explain why.
- **Materials.** Slides use large type, high contrast, real titles and alt text. Documents use plain language, headings and tables with header rows. Videos, if you add any, need captions [INSTITUTION: confirm your standard, such as WCAG 2.1 AA, with your accessibility office; VERIFY]. Request alternate formats at any time.
- **Time and setting.** Extra time, breaks, a quiet space, a seated option and assistive technology are always fine for any activity or assessment.
- **Accommodations.** Contact [DISABILITY SERVICES OFFICE, EMAIL, PHONE] early; your instructor will implement approved

accommodations and will not ask you to disclose a diagnosis [VERIFY with your office].

- **Low-device and low-bandwidth.** Every demo has a paper version. No assignment requires a device you do not have.

10 Academic integrity

YOU ARE PREPARING TO be a trusted adult for children, so the standard here is plain honesty.

- Your own words and your own practice are the point of the journal, practicum and reflections.
- Cite what you use. For statistics, cite the primary source (the organization's own page or report), not a news story about it. If you cannot confirm a figure, say so and mark it [VERIFY]. Invented citations and invented numbers are the most serious integrity violation in this course.
- The Hackles kit is CC BY-NC 4.0 for lesson text: credit it when you adapt it. The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license; use them unaltered, for classroom and family use.
- Collaboration: you may talk through ideas and give each other feedback. Submit work that is your own. Group work is labeled as such.
- Privacy is part of integrity: never put real student names, student work, real passwords, or any real incident detail in an assignment, a chat, or an AI tool.

Violations follow [INSTITUTION'S ACADEMIC INTEGRITY POLICY].

11 Generative AI use policy

THIS POLICY TRIES TO be honest about how people actually work and workable for a whole term. It uses three tiers.

TIER	WHAT IT COVERS	RULE
Allowed, no disclosure needed	Spelling and grammar help; accessibility tools such as text-to-speech, dictation and translation of your own text; searching for a primary source you then read yourself	Use freely
Allowed with a short AI use note	Brainstorming activity ideas or hooks; asking for a plain-language explanation of a concept; generating practice questions for yourself; suggesting a structure for a lesson plan	You write the final work yourself. Add a 2 to 4 sentence AI use note at the end: the tool, what you asked, and what you changed or rejected. You verify every fact, statistic and standards code against its primary source

TIER	WHAT IT COVERS	RULE
Not allowed	Writing reflective journal entries or the capstone reflection; generating your practicum responses or what you would say to a child; answering quizzes; producing the final text of the unit plan or capstone plan; inventing citations or statistics	Counts as an integrity violation
Never, for any assignment or any purpose in this course	Entering a real student's name or work, any disclosure or incident detail, a real password or account detail, or anything from a field placement into an AI tool	This is a student-privacy rule; the kit sets the same limit for teachers' use of AI

Why this shape. AI tools can be useful for planning and for removing barriers. They are weak at the things this course grades: your own honest reflection, your own spoken response to a hard moment, and statistics checked at the source. They also invent citations. Verifying what a tool says is itself a course skill (see Week 1, Number Detective).

How it will be checked. The instructor will not rely on AI-detection software as the sole basis for a finding, because such tools are not reliable enough for that [VERIFY with your institution's guidance]. Instead the course uses process evidence: the AI use note, drafts kept in your document history, short in-class writing and a brief conference about your unit plan. If something looks off, the instructor will ask you to talk it through before drawing any conclusion.

Your own future classroom. The course teaches what the kit says to teachers: do not paste student names, student work with personal details or disclosure notes into a chatbot, and follow your district's AI policy [VERIFY].

12 Learning together about hard topics: care for you

SOME OF THIS MATERIAL touches real life for some of us. The course is built with trauma-informed practice for the candidates as well as for the children you will teach.

- **Content notes.** Each high-care session begins with a content note. Cards are fictional and non-graphic. Nothing asks you to describe a personal experience, and you will never be asked to play a child who is harmed.
- **Choice and opt-out.** You may take any role, pass, step out, or choose the written alternative without penalty and without explanation. Traffic-light cards (green, yellow, red) are used in role-plays.
- **Predictable routine.** Same opening and closing every week. We take a breath, we de-role ("I'm [name], that was pretend"), and we close calmly.
- **Counselor partner.** [NAME] attends Weeks 8 and 9 and is available all term. Campus counseling: [CENTER, PHONE]. If you are in distress at

any time, call or text 988 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org], or text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: crisistextline.org].

- **If you have lived this.** If you are a survivor, it is okay to ask a colleague or counselor to lead sensitive lessons in your future classroom. That is good judgment.
- **A note on what you tell me.** Keep personal experiences out of class discussion and written work unless you choose to share them. Your instructor may have reporting duties for some disclosures. For child abuse and neglect the duty depends on state law and role, and many campuses designate instructors as responsible employees for sexual misconduct [VERIFY your campus policy and state law; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]. If you want complete confidentiality, campus counseling is the better place. [INSTITUTION: insert your Title IX and responsible-employee language here.]

13 Data and privacy in this course

- No student accounts and no student data are collected in this course, ever. Candidates never bring student information into class.
- The Pre- and Post-Course Confidence Surveys stay with you; the instructor records completion only.
- Role-play or micro-teach recordings (optional, with everyone's consent) are used only for scoring and are deleted at the end of term [VERIFY your retention policy].
- If your program wishes to publish findings about this course, that is research and needs its own review. See the research toolkit in kit/28_College/research, which includes an IRB-ready protocol template [COUNSEL AND IRB TO CONFIRM].

14 Field experience in brief

AT LEAST 12 ON-SITE hours: two observations, two supervised lessons (standard-care only), and the capstone workshop for adults. Background checks, mandated-reporter orientation, mentor teacher agreements, the no-student-data rule and the Response Readiness gate are in the Field Placement Guide. In-service teachers use their own classroom with an administrator's written approval.

15 Required and optional readings

REQUIRED: THE HACKLES KIT documents named in each week (all free).

Optional: primary-source reports. Every source in the Reading List is either verified in the kit's verification reports or marked [VERIFY]. See the Reading List.

16 Honesty statement about the kit

HACKLES HAS NOT BEEN reviewed, approved or endorsed by any state education agency or accrediting body. It has not been evaluated in a controlled trial, and this course does not claim that it works to prevent harm. What the kit offers is a set of teaching methods consistent with what prevention science suggests about active, repeated, skill-based teaching, much of which comes from an adjacent field, plus simple ways to measure and report changes in students' survey answers. Part of your job in this course is to say that plainly to colleagues, parents and administrators.

17 Variants

- **1-credit workshop (15 hours)** and **non-credit PD (6 hours)**: see Workshop Variants and PD Version. The PD version makes no claim of state approval or credit.
- **Instructors**: see the Instructor Notes for timing, how to run sensitive sessions, trauma-informed practice, and working with a counselor partner.

This syllabus is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your institution's counsel on reporting duties, accessibility, privacy and licensing.